

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

EDC 104: “INTRODUCTION TO DOCTRINE”

The Meaning and Necessity of Doctrine

Doctrine is one of the most misunderstood words in the Christian faith, yet it is one of the most essential. Many believers associate doctrine with cold theology, arguments, or intellectual pride, but biblically, doctrine is neither abstract nor optional.

Doctrine simply means **teaching that communicates truth**: truth is revealed by God, received by faith, and lived out in obedience.

The word “doctrine” comes from the Latin *doctrina*, meaning instruction or teaching. In Scripture, the idea appears frequently under terms such as *teaching*, *sound doctrine*, or *the faith once delivered*. When the New Testament speaks of doctrine, it is referring to the **content of what Christians believe about God, salvation, Christ, the Spirit, and life**.

“Doctrine” simply refers to teaching. In the Greek New Testament, two terms are used for doctrine: *Didache* and *Didaskalia*, both conveying the idea of instruction, education, or explanation. In Proverbs 4:1–2, doctrine is closely associated with instruction and understanding.

A doctrine is a clear statement that expresses a particular truth; it is not framed as a command or a question. The term “doctrinal” relates to matters concerning such teachings. Jesus Himself was known for teaching doctrine (see Matthew 7:28; Mark 1:22; Luke 4:32, among others). One defining feature of the early New Testament believers was their commitment to the Apostles’ teaching, as seen in Acts 2:42.

Paul exhorts Timothy, “*Take heed unto thyself, and unto the doctrine; continue in them: for in doing this thou shalt both save thyself, and them that hear thee*” (1 Timothy 4:16). This statement alone shows that doctrine is not detached from salvation or spiritual life. Doctrine shapes understanding, guards truth, and preserves the soul.

Christianity is not merely a spiritual feeling or moral system; **Christianity is a revealed faith**. Without doctrine, faith loses clarity. Belief becomes undefined, experience becomes uncontrolled, and spirituality becomes subjective. **Doctrine gives form to faith, just as bones give structure to the human body.**

The necessity of doctrine arises from the fact that God has spoken. **Once God reveals truth, that truth must be understood, articulated, and preserved.** Doctrine is the Church’s faithful response to divine revelation.

Doctrine and Divine Revelation

Doctrine does not begin with human reasoning or philosophical reflection; it begins with **God’s self-disclosure** and that is why **Christianity is not humanity’s search for God, but God’s initiative to reveal Himself.**

Scripture teaches that God reveals Himself in two primary ways. **First**, through **general revelation**, seen in creation, conscience, and human history. *“The heavens declare the glory of God”* (Psalm 19:1). General revelation makes humanity accountable but does not provide saving knowledge.

Second, and more importantly, God reveals Himself through **special revelation**, which includes Scripture and the person of Jesus Christ. Hebrews declares, *“God, who at sundry times and in divers manners spake in time past unto the fathers by the prophets, hath in these last days spoken unto us by his Son”* (Hebrews 1:1–2).

Doctrine arises when the Church listens carefully to what God has revealed and faithfully articulates it. It is not speculation about God; **it is submission to what God has made known.**

The Holy Spirit plays a crucial role here. Jesus promised that the Spirit would guide believers into all truth (John 16:13). Doctrine, therefore, is both **revealed truth and Spirit-illuminated understanding**. **Without the Spirit, doctrine becomes dead knowledge. Without doctrine, spiritual experience becomes unstable.**

Scripture as the Foundation of All Doctrine

All Christian doctrine must be rooted in Scripture. The Bible is not merely a devotional book or historical record; it is the **authoritative witness to God’s redemptive truth**. Paul affirms that *“All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine”* (2 Timothy 3:16).

Doctrine Must Be True and Sound. God says, *“I give you good doctrine”* (Pro. 4:2). Acts 13:12 calls it *“the doctrine of the Lord.”* True doctrine must come from God, not from mere men. Even the Lord Jesus said, *“My doctrine is not Mine, but His who sent Me”* (John 7:16). Paul placed a very high value on doctrine which is true and must be sound (I Tim. 1:3, 10, 4:6, 13, 16, 5:17, 6:1, 3; 2 Tim. 1:3, 3:10, 16, 4:2-3; Titus 1:9, 2:1, 7, 10). 2 John 9-10 says that we are to ignore any so-called Christian who believes or teaches anything other than “the doctrine of Christ” (the doctrine from and about Christ)

Doctrine is not invented; it is **drawn out of Scripture**. This is why sound doctrine depends on faithful interpretation. The Church does not stand above Scripture but under it. Whenever doctrine moves beyond or against Scripture, it becomes error, no matter how spiritual it sounds.

The unity of Scripture is essential here. Doctrine must be consistent with the whole counsel of God, not built on isolated verses. **True doctrine harmonizes the Old and New Testaments, Law and Gospel, promise and fulfillment.**

This commitment protects the Church from extra-biblical teachings, personal revelations that contradict Scripture, and cultural distortions of the faith. Scripture remains the final authority by which all doctrine is tested.

Doctrine, Faith, and Spiritual Life

Biblically, faith is never a blind belief. Faith responds to truth. Paul writes, “Faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God” (Romans 10:17). Doctrine gives faith content. Without doctrine, faith has no clear object.

Assurance of salvation, growth in holiness, and confidence in prayer all depend on sound doctrine. A believer who does not understand what Christ has accomplished will struggle with fear, insecurity, and confusion.

Spiritual experience must be governed by truth. The Bible never places experience above doctrine; rather, experience is judged by doctrine. John warns believers to “*try the spirits whether they are of God*” (1 John 4:1). Doctrine provides the standard for discernment.

At the same time, doctrine is not meant to suppress spiritual life. Properly understood, doctrine **fuels worship**, deepens prayer, and stabilizes spiritual growth. Word and Spirit are not enemies; they are partners.

Categories of Christian Doctrine

Doctrine is organized not to complicate faith but to clarify it. Just as the human body has systems, Christian theology has doctrinal categories that help believers understand the full scope of God’s revelation.

These include the **doctrine of God, Christ, the Holy Spirit, salvation, the Church,** and last things. This structure helps believers avoid imbalance: overemphasizing one truth while neglecting others.

Order in doctrine reflects the order of divine revelation. God is not the author of confusion, and doctrine reflects His clarity and coherence.

While doctrine is rooted in Scripture, understanding its development helps the believer navigate challenges and avoid error. The early church wrestled with heresies, debates, and controversies that clarified core truths such as:

- The Trinity: God is one essence in three persons—Father, Son, and Holy Spirit (Matthew 28:19; John 1:1–3).
- Christology: Jesus Christ is fully God and fully man, essential for salvation (Colossians 2:9; Philippians 2:5–8).
- Soteriology: Salvation is by grace through faith, grounded in Christ’s finished work (Ephesians 2:8–9).

Understanding these historical developments equips disciples to defend the faith and apply it faithfully.

Orthodoxy, Heresy, and Error

Orthodoxy means **right belief**: belief that is aligned with apostolic teaching. Standing firm in truth, rejecting destructive falsehood, humbly correcting and restoring misunderstanding. It protects who Jesus is, salvation by grace and authority of the Scripture (2Tim 1:13-14; Titus 2:1).

Heresy arises when core truths are distorted, denied, or replaced. The teachings that corrupt the foundation of faith. Heresy changes the gospel, denies Christ's true nature and add works as a requirement for salvation (2Pet 2:1; Gal 1:8).

Error often begins subtly, not with open rebellion but with partial truths taken out of balance. The incomplete or mistake understanding that can be corrected. (James 5:19-20; Acts 18:24-26).

The New Testament repeatedly warns against false teaching because doctrine shapes destiny. Paul cautions that "*the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine*" (2 Timothy 4:3). This warning remains deeply relevant.

Guarding doctrine is not arrogance; it is love for truth and protection for God's people.

The early Church "*continued steadfastly in the apostles' doctrine*" (Acts 2:42). Doctrine created unity, preserved truth, and shaped worship. **Where doctrine weakens, the Church drifts.**

Teaching is not optional ministry; it is foundational. A Church without doctrine becomes vulnerable to manipulation, emotionalism, and error.

Doctrine and Christian Character

What a believer truly believes will eventually shape how they live. Sound doctrine produces sound living. Paul links doctrine directly to godliness, speaking of "*sound doctrine which accords with godliness*" (Titus 1:1).

Doctrine forms conscience, disciplines desire, and aligns character with truth. When doctrine is separated from character, it becomes hypocrisy. When character is pursued without doctrine, it becomes moralism.

Doctrinal understanding grows over time. It requires humility, patience, and teachability. Mature believers learn to test teachings, weigh interpretations, and remain anchored in Scripture.

Doctrinal stability protects believers from confusion and spiritual instability.

Doctrine without practice is hollow; practice without doctrine is unstable. Jesus rebuked the Pharisees for knowing Scripture yet failing to apply it:

"You study the Scriptures diligently because you think that in them you have eternal life. These are the very Scriptures that testify about me, yet you refuse to come to me to have life" (John 5:39-40).

Similarly, the early church demonstrated the integration of doctrine and practice. Acts 2:42 emphasizes that the disciples devoted themselves to teaching, fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayer. Doctrine informed both their understanding of God and their communal life.

The Goal of Doctrine

The ultimate goal of doctrine is **the knowledge of God that leads to love, obedience, and worship**. Doctrine is not an end in itself. It is a means by which believers know God truly and serve Him faithfully.

True doctrine produces reverence, not pride; devotion, not division; mission, not stagnation.

The Role of Doctrine in Awakening Ecclesia (EDC)

In AE (EDC), doctrine is integrated into spiritual formation to ensure disciples are both knowledgeable and Spirit-led. The teaching of doctrine:

- Anchors faith in Scripture, preventing deviation into error or superficial religiosity.
- Shapes character and ethics, linking belief with obedience.
- Equips leaders and disciples for ministry, teaching, and witness.

Doctrine is not studied in isolation; it interacts with spiritual disciplines, character formation, and Pentecostal experience, producing holistic disciples who are doctrinally sound, spiritually empowered, and practically effective.

Summary

Introduction to doctrine provides the framework for understanding, defending, and applying God's truth. It grounds the believer in Scripture, shapes character, informs ethics, equips for ministry, and protects against error.

A disciple grounded in doctrine is stable, wise, obedient, and effective, capable of teaching others, resisting deception, and manifesting Christlike character in every sphere.

Signed:

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